



PHYSICALLY CHALLENGED STUDENTS ATTEND A CLASS AT THE DSMRU

Children of a Lesser God

At about 22 mn—and that was almost a decade ago—the nation's physically challenged are no marginal group

	Population	Percentage (%)
Total population	1.03 bn	--
Total physically challenged population	21.90 mn	2.1
Disability rate (per lakh population)	2,130	--
Type of Disability		
(a) In seeing	10.63 mn	1.0
(b) In speech	1.64 mn	0.2
(c) In hearing	1.26 mn	0.1
(d) In movement	6.10 mn	0.6
(e) Mental	2.26 mn	0.2

Source: Census of India 2001

98.8 per cent of the differently abled youth have no access to higher education

Only two universities in India, BHU and AMU, have more than 200 physically challenged students

Most universities admit to a lack of infrastructure, trained staff and equipment

washrooms have been designed with ramps and holding bars. He said that even the study material and technology have been modified to suit the students' needs, like books in Braille for the visually challenged students. Fifty per cent of seats in each course have been reserved for normal students with an aim to integrate regular and the differently abled students. It was on Satish's petition to the Lucknow bench of the Allahabad High Court that the state had to ensure all facilities to the visually challenged.

"In the 2001 Census, the population of the physically challenged in India was about 22 million, of whom 48 per cent were partially or completely blind and 25 per cent physically challenged," says Satish. Mayawati has set up a special committee under Satish's chairmanship to submit a report for taking welfare measures for the differently abled.

"This is my small contribution to the physically challenged," said the chief minister while inaugurating the university. Apart from providing an education, the DSMRU is also assuring placements for the students pursuing courses like hearing impairment and mental retardation, says the registrar of the rehabilitation university, S.K. Srivastava. "We are already receiving requests from schools and colleges for qualified teachers," he says.

"We have no words to express our gratitude to the chief minister and Mishra who has been instrumental in setting up the rehabilitation university," says S.K. Singh, general secretary of the National Association of the Visually Handicapped. He says that not even 3,000 physically challenged persons of the 35 lakh in the state make it to colleges and universities. "The condition in the rural areas, especially that of women, is pathetic,"

says Singh, adding that hundreds of posts reserved for the differently abled are lying vacant and the Government should look into it.

Singh said that there are many institutions which provide such an education, but this university is one of its kind as this is where the physically challenged can receive higher education and get proper jobs as well. "We had been liabilities on our families and on society. But the DSMRU has changed our lives. It has elevated us to the status of regular human beings who can earn and feed their families also," says visually impaired student Dinesh Kumar, from Deoria district. The university is showered with calls from all over the country from students with a range of impairments and specific learning difficulties to know about the details of admission, says Srivastava. It's a start, but there's a long way to go. ■